and hone their innovation skills. The time allocated for students in Atal Tinkering Labs can vary depending on the school. While the recommended time is one to two periods, flexibility exists based on the school's schedule and resource availability. Of over 200,000 senior secondary schools in India, only a few have ATLs, with time allocations varying based on school resources.

How is the creative output of students assessed in Atal Tinkering Labs?

Exams focus on conventional subjects, but ATL emphasises creative output through competitions fostering essential digital skills. Our flagship challenge, the ATL Marathon, introduces a theme and provides various problem statements based on that theme to the students who craft significant projects within their Atal Tinkering Labs. They record the project's video and submit it to us for evaluation. This year's ATL Marathon has been conducted in collaboration with UNICEF.

We have introduced the National Space Innovation Challenge. In this challenge, students build projects centred around a specific space-related theme. Recent advancements in space exploration have spurred enthusiasm in this domain. In collaboration with Israel's National Space Agency, we encourage students to identify and address space-related problems.

The Atal Tinkerpreneur is a digital bootcamp and competition introduced during the pandemic. It has various sessions and workshops where students are taught essential digital skills, such as creating business plans, mastering digital marketing, formulating go-to-market strategies, and venturing into entrepreneurship.

How do you track students pursuing STEM education post-ATL exposure?

The ATL community, though evolving, witnesses success stories. The impact is tangible, with students winning global competitions, securing funding, and even attaining patents. For instance, one student won $200,000 in the IBM challenge, and another student, Ravinder Bishnoi, recently received ten million rupees in funding through the Atal New India challenge. Students have turned their projects into patents, started their own companies, and gained recognition from major companies such as Microsoft. However, I cannot provide an exact number, as these stories continue to surface through our extensive network of WhatsApp groups and knowledge-sharing channels that connect teachers and principals from every state. Ongoing research studies aim to quantify the program's long-term effects.

How do we assess the number or percentage of students who move on to STEM-related fields?

To be honest, we do not have a specific tracking system for this purpose. We have yet to have the opportunity to assess the exact impact or percentage of students who have participated in the ATL programme. While it is mandatory for every student to have access to ATL, we have not conducted formal assessments to measure the outcomes or long-term effects on students. There are some ongoing research studies aimed at evaluating the impact on students who have been part of ATL for a few years, but as of now, we do not have specific data that quantifies the assessment of students. The research process has already begun, and we expect to have results in two months.

How are ATLs funded?

The government of India provides ₹2 million for establishing an Atal Tinkering Lab. Out of this, ₹1 million are allocated for capital expenses, while the remaining ₹1 million cover operational expenses over five years. Schools apply, and after selection, they receive a grant of ₹1.2 million. This is divided into two parts—₹1 million for capital expenses and setting up the lab with all the necessary equipment and infrastructure and ₹200,000 for operational expenses. After this is exhausted, they can apply for an additional ₹400,000 for operational expenses. This funding pattern continues for two years with ₹200,000 each year and then for the subsequent four years with ₹400,000 each year. The school must apply for the funds at each stage.

How does a school maintain ATL after five years?

The establishment and support of Atal Tinkering Labs involve a hand-holding process. The government provides initial help to set up the lab and supports it for at least five years, with the possibility of extensions. However, the long-term sustainability of the lab becomes the school's responsibility. The government cannot continuously provide funding, and after a certain point, typically around ₹2 million in total revenue, the school is expected to manage and sustain the Atal Tinkering Lab independently.

How are operational expenses audited?

Schools are required to provide a utilisation certificate to the government every year. This certificate details how the grant-in-aid provided by the government has been utilised and spent by the school. The utilisation certificate is a document that outlines how the institution